OHIO

The Buckeye State



Cincinnati in the early 1920s was a city of neighborhoods, each one carrying the flavors and traditions of the people who had claimed it. Macedonian and Greek immigrants had arrived in waves, settling into the West End and Price Hill, opening small restaurants and lunch counters to serve the city's working population. It was in this environment that Tom and John Kiradjieff, two Macedonian brothers, opened a small steam table restaurant near the Empress Burlesque Theater on Vine Street in 1922. They called it the Empress Chili Parlor, and what they served there would permanently alter the way an entire region understood a bowl of chili.

The Kiradjieff brothers were not trying to reinvent American chili. They were doing something far more personal—folding the spice traditions of their homeland into an ingredient that was accessible, affordable, and deeply American. They drew on the warm, layered flavors of Macedonian and Greek cooking, building a sauce fragrant with cinnamon, allspice, cloves, and chocolate, simmered low and long over finely ground beef until the consistency was unlike anything else on the American table. It was thinner than Texas chili, richer in spice, and served not in a bowl alone but ladled generously over a tangle of spaghetti—a nod, food historians believe, to the pasta dishes of the Balkans. Oyster crackers and a mound of finely shredded cheddar finished the plate. A city staple was born.

What made Cincinnati embrace it so completely was the culture that grew around it. The "way" system—two-way, three-way, four-way, five-way—gave diners a language of their own, a shorthand that signaled belonging. To order a five-way with confidence, beans, onions, cheese, and chili over spaghetti, was to announce yourself as someone who knew the city from the inside. By the 1940s and 1950s, chili parlors had multiplied across Cincinnati's neighborhoods the way diners had spread across the rest of the country—familiar, unpretentious, and deeply local. Skyline Chili, founded by Greek immigrant Nicholas Lambrinides in 1949, expanded the tradition further, cementing Cincinnati chili not just as a regional dish but as a civic identity.

Today, Cincinnati chili carries more than a century of immigrant ambition and neighborhood pride in every bowl. When you make this dish in your own kitchen, you are pulling on threads that stretch from the Balkans to the banks of the Ohio River—warm spices, slow heat, and the simple genius of people who saw a new place and seasoned it with everything they brought from home. Follow the recipe, build your layers, and don't skip the cheese. Cincinnati won't let you.

CINCINNATI CHILI

A whisper of cinnamon and chocolate transforms humble meat sauce into a layered obsession that has made grown Ohioans weep with homesickness at the mere mention of Skyline.

Yield: 4–6 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb. ground beef (80% fat)
- 4 cups water
- 1 bay leaf
- 1 Tbsp chili powder
- 1 Tbsp granulated garlic (sub: 2 Tbsp fresh garlic, minced)
- 1 Tbsp onion powder (sub: one sweet onion, minced)
- 1 Tbsp sweet paprika
- 1 ½ tsp salt, plus more to taste
- ½ tsp ground allspice
- ½ tsp ground black pepper
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground cloves
- ½ tsp ground cumin
- ½ tsp oregano
- ¼ tsp cayenne pepper (adjust to taste)
- ½ tsp cocoa
- ⅓ cup tomato paste
- 1 Tbsp red wine vinegar (sub: 1 Tbsp apple cider vinegar)
- 1 Tbsp Worcestershire sauce
- 8 oz. spaghetti noodles
- 1 cup shredded cheddar cheese (optional)
- 2 cups cooked kidney beans (optional)
- ½ cup diced sweet onions (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Make the slurry*: Add ground beef and water to a large pot and mix until it forms a slurry mix. Break up the ground beef with a whisk or potato masher. You want the beef broken up into bits.
2. *Season*: Add all spices, cocoa, tomato paste, red wine vinegar, and Worcestershire sauce to the ground beef slurry and mix well.
3. *Simmer*: Heat the slurry mix on high until boiling. Once boiling, reduce heat to a simmer, uncovered, for 2–3 hours.
4. *Cook the noodles*: Once the chili is almost done, prepare the noodles according to package instructions.
5. *Serve*: Choose your style, a 2-way, 5-way or any way in between!

NOTES & TIPS

- 2-Way: Noodles; Chili
- 3-Way: Noodles; Chili; Shredded Cheddar
- 4-Way: Noodles; Chili; Shredded Cheddar; Kidney Beans
- 5-Way: Noodles; Chili; Shredded Cheddar; Kidney Beans; Sweet Onions

TIME-SAVER TIP

- You can use an Instant Pot to save time. Simply reduce the water to 3 cups, mix all ingredients in the Instant Pot, select Pressure and cook on High pressure for 30 mins.

ILLUSTRATION PLACEHOLDER

Cincinnati Chili — finished dish illustration

Food only (finished dish, ingredients or preparation) — no people